collaborators in the past 15 years and who has written yet another cameo for him in the 2023 release *Ghoomer*, puts his finger too on that X-factor. It's born of "his effort and the effort of the world which has preserved the myth", he says. "What has happened due to it is that we are not able to fathom this entity, which will never come again. Cinema is never going to have stars like Bachchan because they (the present lot) are too accessible and don't have that kind of bigness." The enigma endures, especially since Bachchan has cut down his media interactions in the past decade. Even those who worked with him in the early stages of his career, like renowned screenwriter-lyricist Javed Akhtar, who co-wrote some of Bachchan's most iconic roles in *Zanjeer* and *Deewar*, say, "Anybody who claims to know Amitabh Bachchan is lying. He is a very reserved and private person."

If there's one platform where audiences come closest to getting to know Bachchan, it's *KBC*. Here, he shares vignettes of his life and career

That trait was indeed partly why a perception was fostered of a man who came out of nowhere to kick down the doors of Hindi cinema. But of course, Amitabh did not come out of nowhere. Born to renowned Hindi poet Harivansh Rai Bachchan (né Srivastava; 1907-2003) and his Sikh wife Teji, a psychology professor and social activist, there was quite a bit of old-style legacy there—including a storied bond with the Nehru-Gandhi family. Nehru had sponsored Harivansh Rai's senior doctoral thesis at Cambridge, and on his return, he had joined as head of the External Affairs Ministry's Hindi division. Amitabh and his brother Ajitabh had thus been friends with the Gandhi siblings—Rajiv and Sanjay—since childhood. In fact, in January 1968, a year before Amitabh debuted in cinema, as Sonia Maino arrived from Italy to marry Rajiv Gandhi, it was Amitabh who received her. And she stayed at the Bachchan residence in Delhi for a few weeks. But while that family frienship was to sour, his own poet-father would remain an endless inspirational resource for Amitabh.In a shoot for an interview to INDIA TODAY in 2004, when our photographer Bandeep Singh asked him about that influence, he said, "For me, my father was a colossus. If I can read all that he has written in my lifetime, I'd have attained salvation." That inner quietude—which forms something like a screen between him and the world and often stumps even film industry colleagues—is not surprising then.

If there's one platform where audiences come closest to knowing Bachchan, it is *KBC*. On it, you see him switch from being the teasing paternal figure prodding a contestant on marriage to the empathetic man when a woman bemoans not being allowed to study further. He also discloses memorable instances from his





By SIDDHARTHA BASU

"A rare cine actor who has mastered anchoring"

I know of no other 80-year-old who goes through the grind of recording an elaborate, high-intensity show like *Kaun Banega Crorepati* with such zest. Whatever his health issues, tiredness from long hours, stresses and strains of being an uber public figure, they all get set aside once Amitabh Bachchan gears up to get into the 'zone'. He routinely clocks in 12-14 hours on the sets daily, turning around an average of two episodes of 90 minutes each day.